Policy & Strategy Lab

Instructor Guide, Week 2: Situate and prioritise

This guide covers Days 6 to 10. Each day follows the same pattern: an overview, the session plan, preparation, a slide-by-slide teaching narrative that matches the day's PowerPoint, likely misconceptions, discussion questions with what strong answers include, full facilitation notes for the activity, the workbook application, assessment, readings and the transition to the next day.

The running case in every demonstration is Madhyapur, a stylised city. Its figures are illustrative and must never be presented as real data. Rules, schemes and institutions named alongside it (the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2016, Swachh Bharat Mission (Urban) 2.0, the Seventh and Twelfth Schedules) are real; check current details before teaching.

Day 6: Jurisdiction, money and delivery

Item	Detail
Week	2: Situate and prioritise (Monday)
Central question	Who has the authority to act on this problem, where does the money come from, and where does delivery break down?
Session outcome	Each participant has mapped the jurisdiction, funding route and delivery chain for your case, and run a PESTLE check on your issue tree.
Competencies	D1, D2, D3, D5
Anchor tool	Delivery chain map
Supporting tools (demonstrated only)	The Seventh Schedule and local government schedules; Reading a budget line; PESTLE as a completeness check
Theory link	Lant Pritchett and Devesh Kapur: At which link in the delivery chain does intent at the top stop becoming action on the ground?
Gate	No gate today.

Learning objectives

1. Locate your subject in the Seventh Schedule, and in the Eleventh or Twelfth Schedule where relevant.
2. Trace how the activity is funded: scheme, budget head and cost sharing.
3. Map the delivery chain from policy-maker to citizen and mark the likely break point.
4. Use PESTLE to check your issue tree for missing factors.

Session plan

Minutes	Block	Length
0 to 10	Opening problem	10 minutes
10 to 35	Concept: three kinds of power	25 minutes
35 to 55	Demonstration: Madhyapur chain	20 minutes
55 to 85	Activity: follow the money	30 minutes
85 to 110	Own case: chain and funding	25 minutes
110 to 120	Debrief and exit task	10 minutes

Preparation and materials

- The Day 6 slide deck (03 Slides)
- Worksheet 3.1 in Workbook 3
- Extracts of the Seventh, Eleventh and Twelfth Schedules
- Scheme guideline extracts
- A published budget analysis for each case
- Laptops or phones for checking

Indian policy context

Solid waste management appears in the Twelfth Schedule, added by the 74th Amendment, as a function states may devolve to municipalities. Public health and sanitation, and local government, are State List subjects. Union influence arrives through missions such as Swachh Bharat Mission (Urban) 2.0 and through Finance Commission grants.

Teaching narrative, slide by slide

Slide 1. Title slide. Week 2 opens. Remind participants that Gate 1 feedback arrives tomorrow. Today's content is the most India-specific of the course: three reality tests begin here.

Slide 2. Today. Session outcome: by the end of the session each participant has mapped the jurisdiction, funding route and delivery chain for your case, and run a PESTLE check on your issue tree.

Slide 3. Opening problem. Take three examples from the room. Typical ones: school education, urban water supply, public health. Use them to introduce the three kinds of power on the next slide.

Slide 4. Three different kinds of power. This is the first reality test: jurisdiction. Ask participants to name, for their own case, who holds each power. Many will be unsure about the local body; that is normal, and today's worksheet fixes it.

Slide 5. Where some public subjects sit. Read one row slowly: the 74th Amendment added the Twelfth Schedule, which lists functions that state legislatures may devolve to municipalities. Whether a function is actually devolved, with staff and funds, varies by state. That gap between the schedule and practice is itself a common finding in case work.

Slide 6. Where the money comes from. The second reality test: money. Allocation, release and spending are different stages, and each can fail. Spending is also not the same as delivery. Ask participants to look up whether their problem is funded through a centrally sponsored scheme, and the sharing pattern.

Slide 7. The Madhyapur delivery chain. The third reality test begins here: the front line. Walk the chain from left to right. At each link ask: who is responsible, what do they control, and how would we know if this link is working? The dashed arrow marks the hypothesised break. It is a hypothesis, connected to H1 in the register on Day 9.

Slide 8. A thinker for your case. Lant Pritchett and Devesh Kapur, "Is India a Flailing State?" (2009); "Why Does the Indian State Both Fail and Succeed?" (2020). Pritchett described a state whose capable head is not reliably connected to its limbs. Kapur showed that the Indian state can manage some complex tasks at enormous scale while performing poorly on core everyday public goods. Put the question to the room: At which link in the delivery chain does intent at the top stop becoming action on the ground? Then ask each participant to answer it for their own case in one sentence.

Slide 9. PESTLE as a completeness check, not an essay. PESTLE grew out of Francis Aguilar's environmental scanning work in the 1960s and is widely used in strategy practice. Its weakness is that it produces lists, not arguments. Used as a checklist against the issue tree, it is quick and useful. Ask: which factor exposed a missing branch in your tree?

Slide 10. Activity: Follow the money. Participants often confuse who funds with who decides. Insist on three separate answers: who legislates, who administers, who pays. Have the evidence checker verify one claim live against the source.

Slide 11. Your case: Worksheet 3.1. Individual application, about 20 minutes. Circulate and check that every participant is working on their own case. Help participants who cannot find their subject's list entry: start from the Constitution's schedules, then the relevant scheme guideline.

Slide 12. What to take away. Ask two participants to state the takeaway they found least obvious, then close with the exit task: Name the body that holds the power your recommendation will need most.

Slide 13. Before the next session. Find the most recent budget figure for the scheme or head that funds your problem, with year and source, and note it for your evidence register (which opens on Day 10). Check whether a CAG report, standing committee report or social audit has examined the service. About 45 minutes.

Likely misconceptions

Misconception	How to respond
The Union government can fix anything with a scheme.	Schemes bring money and guidelines, but delivery often depends on states and local bodies whose incentives differ.
If funds are allocated, the service is delivered.	Allocation, release and spending are different stages, and spending is not delivery. Each can fail.
PESTLE is an analysis.	It is a checklist. It tells you where to look, not what is true.

Discussion questions

Question	What strong answers include
Why do Indian reforms so often fail at the last link?	Frontline capacity, incentives and supervision are thinnest there. Strong answers use Pritchett's head-and-limbs image and give an example from their case.
When does following the money change a recommendation?	When the recommended action has no budget line, or when funding conditions rule it out. Strong answers show how the funding route constrains their options.

Activity: Follow the money

Element	Detail
Purpose	Trace how a public service is authorised, funded and delivered, from the Constitution to the citizen.
Scenario	Each pod takes one common case: wage payments under the rural employment guarantee; school meals (PM POSHAN); staffing at primary health centres; or a city bus service. Using the Constitution, scheme guidelines and a published budget analysis, find who legislates, who administers and who pays.
Group size	Pods of four, one case per pod
Time	30 minutes
Materials	Extracts of the Seventh, Eleventh and Twelfth Schedules; Scheme guideline extracts; A published budget analysis for each case; Laptops or phones for checking
Expected output	A delivery chain with jurisdiction, funding and a marked break point

Steps.

1. Find where the subject sits: a Union, State or Concurrent List entry, or a local government schedule.
2. Find the scheme or budget line that funds it, and the sharing pattern.
3. Map the delivery chain from ministry to citizen in five or six links.
4. Mark where delivery is most likely to break, and why.
5. Present in two minutes; another pod's evidence checker verifies one claim.

Facilitation. Participants often confuse who funds with who decides. Insist on three separate answers: who legislates, who administers, who pays. Have the evidence checker verify one claim live against the source.

Debrief questions.

- Where did the three kinds of power sit with different bodies?
- Which link in your chain is weakest, and what evidence would show it?
- What would a recommendation addressed to the wrong level look like?

Evaluation criteria	Common errors
Three kinds of power identified separately	Treating the government as one actor
A funding route with a source	Leaving out the local body
A break point marked with a reason	Citing a budget figure without year and source

Extension for strong groups. Add the accountability institutions: who audits or reviews this service, such as the CAG, a standing committee or a social audit?

Workbook application: Worksheet 3.1, Jurisdiction, funding and delivery chain

Establish who can act on your problem, with what money, and where delivery is most likely to break. Help participants who cannot find their subject's list entry: start from the Constitution's schedules, then the relevant scheme guideline.

Hand in. Worksheet 3.1 by the start of Day 7.

Independent work

Find the most recent budget figure for the scheme or head that funds your problem, with year and source, and note it for your evidence register (which opens on Day 10). Check whether a CAG report, standing committee report or social audit has examined the service. About 45 minutes.

Assessment

Feeds Gate 2. Feedback uses D1, D2, D3 and D5 and tracker code IN1.

Readings

- Essential: Pritchett, "Is India a Flailing State?" (2009), the opening sections.
- Optional: Kapur, "Why Does the Indian State Both Fail and Succeed?" Journal of Economic Perspectives 34, no. 1 (2020).
- Optional: The Constitution of India: the Seventh, Eleventh and Twelfth Schedules.

Close and transition

Exit task: Name the body that holds the power your recommendation will need most. Transition: Tomorrow: the people in the chain. Who has power, who has an interest, and who has no voice?

Day 7: Actors and political economy

Item	Detail
Week	2: Situate and prioritise (Tuesday)
Central question	Who has power over this problem, what do they want, and who is not heard?
Session outcome	Each participant has built a power-interest and incentive matrix for your case that includes the groups with an interest but no voice.
Competencies	D3, D4
Anchor tool	Power-interest map with absent voices
Supporting tools (demonstrated only)	Incentive analysis; Political economy in four questions
Theory link	Elinor Ostrom and Michael Lipsky: Which rules actually govern behaviour here, and what will frontline workers really do?
Gate	No gate today.

Learning objectives

1. Map actors by power over and interest in the outcome.
2. State each key actor's incentive and likely response to change.
3. Identify groups with high interest and little power or voice.
4. Explain how rules in use differ from rules on paper.

Session plan

Minutes	Block	Length
0 to 10	Opening problem	10 minutes
10 to 30	Concept: power, interest, incentives	20 minutes
30 to 45	Demonstration: Madhyapur actors	15 minutes
45 to 85	Activity: stakeholder negotiation	40 minutes
85 to 110	Own case: incentive matrix	25 minutes
110 to 120	Debrief and exit task	10 minutes

Preparation and materials

- The Day 7 slide deck (03 Slides)
- Worksheet 3.2 in Workbook 3
- Seven role cards
- A power-interest grid on the board
- Timer

Indian policy context

A congestion charge in an Indian city centre would affect car owners, bus users, vendors, traffic police and transport operators very differently. The people who gain most, bus commuters, are often the least organised.

Teaching narrative, slide by slide

Slide 1. Title slide. Return Gate 1 feedback at the start. Give participants five minutes to read it before the opening problem, and tell them the revision note at Gate 2 must respond to it.

Slide 2. Today. Session outcome: by the end of the session each participant has built a power-interest and incentive matrix for your case that includes the groups with an interest but no voice.

Slide 3. Opening problem. Write the names on the board in two columns: those who will be heard and those who will not. Bus commuters, domestic workers and delivery riders usually end up in the second column. Keep the board for the negotiation later.

Slide 4. The power-interest map, with absent voices. The power-interest grid is commonly attributed to Aubrey Mendelow's work on stakeholder mapping in the early 1990s. Its usual use is managerial: whom to manage and whom to inform. The Lab's change is deliberate. In public policy, the people with high interest and no power often bear the costs, and their exclusion affects both equity and legitimacy.

Slide 5. Incentives explain behaviour better than attitudes. This is the most important habit of the day. Explanations based on bad attitudes (lazy crews, corrupt inspectors, careless households) are usually incomplete. Ask what makes the observed behaviour rational for each actor.

Slide 6. Rules on paper and rules in use. This bridges to the theory slide. Ostrom's term rules-in-use names the gap between formal and working rules. Lipsky adds the reason: frontline workers face more demands than they can meet, so they ration, simplify and use discretion. Their coping behaviour becomes the policy citizens experience.

Slide 7. A thinker for your case. Elinor Ostrom and Michael Lipsky, Governing the Commons (1990); Street-Level Bureaucracy (1980). Ostrom showed that the rules people actually follow often differ from the formal rules. Lipsky showed that frontline workers make policy through the discretion they exercise under pressure. Put the question to the room: Which rules actually govern behaviour here, and what will frontline workers really do? Then ask each participant to answer it for their own case in one sentence.

Slide 8. Political economy in four questions. These four questions condense problem-driven political economy analysis of the kind the World Bank and others have promoted. The aim is not cynicism but feasibility: a technically sound recommendation that ignores blocking actors will not be implemented.

Slide 9. Activity: Stakeholder negotiation simulation. The bus commuters' role is deliberately weak: no vote and no organisation. Watch whether anyone brings commuters into the deal. Keep strict time; negotiations drift. In the debrief, ask who was absent from the agreement and why.

Slide 10. Your case: Worksheet 3.2. Individual application, about 20 minutes. Circulate and check that every participant is working on their own case. Challenge any incentive written as an attitude, such as does not care, and ask what the system rewards instead.

Slide 11. What to take away. Ask two participants to state the takeaway they found least obvious, then close with the exit task: Name the actor most able to block change in your case, and their incentive to do so.

Slide 12. Before the next session. Find one published source that records the experience of the absent voice in your case, such as a field study, a social audit, testimony to a committee or credible reporting. Note what it adds to your map. About 45 minutes.

Likely misconceptions

Misconception	How to respond
Stakeholder mapping is about managing opposition.	It is about understanding who shapes outcomes, including people without power who bear the costs.
Officials resist reform because they are lazy or corrupt.	Usually they respond rationally to the incentives and constraints they face. Change those and behaviour often changes.
The public interest is obvious.	Different groups have legitimate, conflicting interests. The analyst's job is to make the trade-off visible.

Discussion questions

Question	What strong answers include
Why rename keep informed as absent voices?	Because the usual label treats weak groups as an audience rather than as people whose interests count. Strong answers connect this to equity and to the legitimacy of the eventual recommendation.
How does Lipsky change implementation analysis?	It moves attention to discretion and coping behaviour at the front line. Strong answers predict a specific coping behaviour in their own case.

Activity: Stakeholder negotiation simulation

Element	Detail
Purpose	Experience how power, interest and incentives shape what is feasible, by negotiating a contested policy in role.
Scenario	A large city proposes a congestion charge for private cars entering its central business district at peak hours, with the revenue going to buses. Roles: the municipal commissioner, the traffic police, a bus operators' association, a car owners' group, a street vendors' association, an environmental group, and bus commuters, who have no seat at the table unless someone gives them one.
Group size	Groups of seven or eight, one role each
Time	40 minutes
Materials	Seven role cards; A power-interest grid on the board; Timer
Expected output	A negotiated design and a completed power-interest map

Steps.

1. Read your role card privately: interests, power and red lines.
2. Round one, ten minutes: each role states its position in one minute.
3. Round two, fifteen minutes: negotiate a workable design in coalitions.
4. The commissioner announces a decision and says whom it favours.
5. Step out of role: place every actor on the power-interest map.

Facilitation. The bus commuters' role is deliberately weak: no vote and no organisation. Watch whether anyone brings commuters into the deal. Keep strict time; negotiations drift. In the debrief, ask who was absent from the agreement and why.

Debrief questions.

- Whose interests shaped the final design most: power, interest or argument?
- Who was absent from the deal, and what would it take to include them?
- What will you change in your own stakeholder map after this?

Evaluation criteria	Common errors
Positions linked to interests	Treating all stakeholders as equally powerful
Coalitions formed and explained	Ignoring the actor who can block implementation
Absent voices identified	Assuming the public interest is obvious

Extension for strong groups. Rerun the decision with commuters represented by an organised association. What changes?

Workbook application: Worksheet 3.2, Stakeholder and incentive matrix

Show who shapes your problem, what each actor is rewarded for, and who bears costs without a voice. Challenge any incentive written as an attitude, such as does not care, and ask what the system rewards instead.

Hand in. Worksheet 3.2 by the start of Day 8.

Independent work

Find one published source that records the experience of the absent voice in your case, such as a field study, a social audit, testimony to a committee or credible reporting. Note what it adds to your map. About 45 minutes.

Assessment

Feeds Gate 2. Feedback uses D3 and D4 and tracker code IN2.

Readings

- Essential: Lipsky, Street-Level Bureaucracy (1980), preface and chapter 1, or the introduction to the expanded edition.
- Optional: Ostrom, Governing the Commons (1990), chapter 3 on design principles.
- Optional: Fritz, Kaiser and Levy, Problem-Driven Governance and Political Economy Analysis (World Bank, 2009), the framework section.

Close and transition

Exit task: Name the actor most able to block change in your case, and their incentive to do so.
Transition: Tomorrow we decide which branches of your tree deserve your limited time.

Day 8: Prioritising issues

Item	Detail
Week	2: Situate and prioritise (Wednesday)
Central question	Given limited time, which parts of the problem deserve our attention first?
Session outcome	Each participant has pruned your issue tree by size of effect and ability to influence, and chosen the two or three branches you will analyse.
Competencies	B4
Anchor tool	Pruning matrix: size of effect against ability to influence
Supporting tools (demonstrated only)	Pareto reasoning; Equity check on pruning
Theory link	Herbert Simon: Given limited time and attention, what is good enough to investigate, and what will you knowingly leave out?
Gate	No gate today.

Learning objectives

1. Rate branches by size of effect and ability to influence.
2. Prune low-priority branches with written reasons.
3. Distinguish prioritising issues from prioritising interventions.
4. Explain satisficing and what it means for a four-week analysis.

Session plan

Minutes	Block	Length
0 to 10	Opening problem	10 minutes
10 to 30	Concept: pruning	20 minutes
30 to 50	Demonstration: Madhyapur	20 minutes
50 to 85	Activity: the 80/20 challenge	35 minutes
85 to 110	Own case: pruning matrix	25 minutes
110 to 120	Debrief and exit task	10 minutes

Preparation and materials

- The Day 8 slide deck (03 Slides)
- Worksheet 4.1 in Workbook 4
- Ten leaf cards
- Pruning matrix template

Indian policy context

A municipal health department facing a dengue season cannot study every cause at once. Construction-site water, household storage, drains, reporting by private clinics and surveillance staffing differ both in likely effect and in how far the department can act on them.

Teaching narrative, slide by slide

Slide 1. Title slide. This is McKinsey step three. Make the link back to the issue tree from Day 3: today it gets smaller, deliberately.

Slide 2. Today. Session outcome: by the end of the session each participant has pruned your issue tree by size of effect and ability to influence, and chosen the two or three branches you will analyse.

Slide 3. Opening problem. Most participants say three or four leaves. Ask how they would choose. Answers will include what is easiest to research, which is a trap this session addresses.

Slide 4. The pruning matrix. Ability to influence means within the decision-maker's authority and resources, not easy. Size of effect is a judgement before evidence, so participants should write a reason for each rating. Ask which quadrant most of their own branches fall into; a tree with everything in the top right has not been rated honestly.

Slide 5. Pruning the Madhyapur tree. Point out the last row: recycling markets matter, but the Commissioner cannot influence national prices, so they become context. The second row is kept although influence is only medium, because without processing capacity no collection reform works.

Slide 6. Prioritising issues is not prioritising interventions. This corrects a common confusion in consulting-style courses, including earlier drafts of this one. Using an intervention tool to rank issues smuggles solutions into the diagnosis.

Slide 7. The 80/20 idea, used honestly. The principle is named after Vilfredo Pareto's observations on income distribution and was popularised in quality management by Joseph Juran. Use it to look for concentration, then measure it. The equity caveat matters: pruning by share of total can quietly remove the most affected group.

Slide 8. A thinker for your case. Herbert Simon, Administrative Behavior (1947) and later work on satisficing. Simon argued that decision-makers are boundedly rational: they cannot consider every option, so they search until they find one that is good enough. He called this satisficing. Put the question to the room: Given limited time and attention, what is good enough to investigate, and what will you knowingly leave out? Then ask each participant to answer it for their own case in one sentence.

Slide 9. Three ways prioritisation goes wrong. Ask participants to check their own pruning against each failure. The third is the one most often missed, and today's worksheet includes an explicit equity check.

Slide 10. Activity: The 80/20 challenge. Pods often keep awareness because it is easy to research, and cut migrant housing because it is uncomfortable. Ask whether each cut reflects size of effect or convenience. There is no single right answer; the quality of the reasons is what counts.

Slide 11. Your case: Worksheet 4.1. Individual application, about 20 minutes. Circulate and check that every participant is working on their own case. Ask anyone with more than three priorities which one they would drop if they lost a day.

Slide 12. What to take away. Ask two participants to state the takeaway they found least obvious, then close with the exit task: Name the branch you pruned that you most expect to regret.

Slide 13. Before the next session. For each priority branch, write the one or two questions that, if answered, would most change your recommendation. About 40 minutes.

Likely misconceptions

Misconception	How to respond
Prioritising means ignoring.	Pruned branches are recorded with reasons and can return if evidence demands.
The 80/20 rule is a law.	It is a heuristic for searching. The actual distribution must be found, not assumed.
Ability to influence means easy to do.	It means within the decision-maker's authority and resources, which may still be hard.

Discussion questions

Question	What strong answers include
Why separate size of effect from ability to influence?	Because the largest causes may be beyond reach, and the easiest levers may be trivial. Strong answers show a branch that scores differently on the two.
How does satisficing help a policy analyst?	It legitimises stopping when the analysis is good enough for the decision, provided the analyst states what was left out. Strong answers connect it to the limitations section of the report.

Activity: The 80/20 challenge

Element	Detail
Purpose	Practise pruning under pressure, and defend what you dropped.
Scenario	A municipal health department wants to reduce dengue cases this monsoon. Your pod has a tree with ten leaves: water in construction sites; household water storage; blocked drains; late case reporting by private clinics; fogging coverage; public awareness; housing for migrant workers; vacancies among surveillance staff; laboratory testing capacity; and coordination between the health and engineering departments.
Group size	Pods of four
Time	35 minutes
Materials	Ten leaf cards; Pruning matrix template
Expected output	A pruned tree: three priorities and four written reasons for cuts

Steps.

1. Rate each leaf for size of effect and ability to influence: high, medium or low.
2. Place the leaves on the pruning matrix.
3. Choose three to analyse first; prune at least four, with written reasons.
4. The pod sceptic challenges your weakest pruning decision.
5. Report your three choices and your hardest cut.

Facilitation. Pods often keep awareness because it is easy to research, and cut migrant housing because it is uncomfortable. Ask whether each cut reflects size of effect or convenience. There is no single right answer; the quality of the reasons is what counts.

Debrief questions.

- What was your hardest cut, and what reason did you write?
- Did any pod prune by convenience rather than importance?
- What evidence would make you restore a pruned branch?

Evaluation criteria	Common errors
Ratings justified	Keeping every branch

Evaluation criteria	Common errors
At least four written reasons for cuts	Pruning without reasons
Priorities within the decision-maker's reach	Confusing leaves with interventions

Extension for strong groups. Re-rate the leaves from the point of view of the state health department. What changes?

Workbook application: Worksheet 4.1, Pruning matrix

Choose the two or three branches of your tree that deserve your limited time, and record why the rest are set aside. Ask anyone with more than three priorities which one they would drop if they lost a day.

Hand in. Worksheet 4.1 by the start of Day 9.

Independent work

For each priority branch, write the one or two questions that, if answered, would most change your recommendation. About 40 minutes.

Assessment

Feeds Gate 2. Feedback uses B4 and tracker code ST2.

Readings

- Essential: Conn and McLean, Bulletproof Problem Solving (2018), the chapter on prioritisation and pruning the tree.
- Optional: Simon, Herbert A. "A Behavioral Model of Rational Choice." Quarterly Journal of Economics 69, no. 1 (1955).

Close and transition

Exit task: Name the branch you pruned that you most expect to regret. Transition: Tomorrow your priority branches become testable hypotheses, and you defend them in the Hypothesis Battle.

Day 9: Hypotheses

Item	Detail
Week	2: Situate and prioritise (Thursday)
Central question	What do we currently believe explains the problem, and how could we prove ourselves wrong?
Session outcome	Each participant has written a hypothesis register with disconfirming evidence and rival explanations, and defended it in the Hypothesis Battle.
Competencies	F1, F2, F3
Anchor tool	Hypothesis register
Supporting tools (demonstrated only)	Assumption mapping; Competing explanations
Theory link	None today.
Gate	No gate today.

Learning objectives

1. Write three to five testable hypotheses from your priority branches.
2. State, for each, the evidence that would weaken it.
3. Name a rival explanation and the evidence that would tell the two apart.
4. Separate assumptions from hypotheses and decide which to test first.

Session plan

Minutes	Block	Length
0 to 10	Opening problem	10 minutes
10 to 25	Concept: testable hypotheses	15 minutes
25 to 40	Demonstration: Madhyapur register	15 minutes
40 to 85	Thursday challenge: hypothesis battle	45 minutes
85 to 110	Own case: hypothesis register	25 minutes
110 to 120	Debrief and exit task	10 minutes

Preparation and materials

- The Day 9 slide deck (03 Slides)
- Worksheet 4.2 in Workbook 4
- Six explanation cards
- Timer
- A register template on the board

Indian policy context

Low participation of women in paid work has several competing explanations in the Indian research literature, including care responsibilities, the availability of suitable local jobs, social norms, safety and transport, and household income. Several may be true at once, in different proportions in different places.

Teaching narrative, slide by slide

Slide 1. Title slide. Second Thursday challenge. Keep the concept block brisk; the battle needs its full 45 minutes.

Slide 2. Today. Session outcome: by the end of the session each participant has written a hypothesis register with disconfirming evidence and rival explanations, and defended it in the Hypothesis Battle.

Slide 3. Opening problem. The second sentence is always harder, and many participants cannot write it. That difficulty is today's subject. Ask two people to read both sentences.

Slide 4. A hypothesis is a claim evidence could show to be wrong. Each testable version names a comparison. That is the trick: a hypothesis becomes testable when it says what should differ between two situations. Ask participants to convert one untestable statement from their own register on the spot.

Slide 5. The Madhyapur hypothesis register. Point out that H1 and its rival could both be partly true, and that the disconfirming test for H1 needs a comparison across contracts, which is why the workplan on Day 10 looks at other cities. Compare the register with the sealed Day 3 answer: H1 is the sealed answer, now exposed to tests.

Slide 6. Assumption mapping: which beliefs to test first. Every analysis rests on beliefs not being tested. Making them explicit stops them becoming invisible. The top-right quadrant drives the Day 10 workplan.

Slide 7. Guarding against confirmation bias. These practices echo the analysis of competing hypotheses developed for intelligence analysts by Richards Heuer, which asks analysts to look for evidence that discriminates between hypotheses rather than evidence consistent with a favourite.

Slide 8. Activity: The hypothesis battle. The aim is to sharpen, not to win. Award no points for persuasion; award them for the most precise disconfirming test. Point out that several explanations can be partly true at once, which is why the register keeps rivals rather than declaring a winner. The Periodic Labour Force Survey is the obvious public source if participants ask what data could decide.

Slide 9. Your case: Worksheet 4.2. Individual application, about 20 minutes. Circulate and check that every participant is working on their own case. Ask each participant to read one hypothesis and its disconfirming test aloud to their pod sceptic.

Slide 10. What to take away. Ask two participants to state the takeaway they found least obvious, then close with the exit task: Write the single piece of evidence that would most damage your favourite hypothesis.

Slide 11. Before the next session. For each hypothesis, find one published source that could test it, and check that it covers your place and period. About 45 minutes.

Likely misconceptions

Misconception	How to respond
A good analyst proves the hypothesis.	A good analyst tries to disprove it and reports what survives.
Rival explanations are a sign of weak analysis.	They are the analysis. A recommendation that ignores the strongest rival is fragile.
Confidence should be high by now.	Confidence should match the evidence. Low confidence on Day 9 is normal and honest.

Discussion questions

Question	What strong answers include
Why write the disconfirming test first?	Because once evidence is in hand, it is easy to read it as supportive. Strong answers describe a moment they caught themselves doing this.
Can two rival hypotheses both be true?	Yes; many outcomes have several causes acting together. Strong answers explain how they would judge the relative weight of each.

Activity: The hypothesis battle

Element	Detail
Purpose	Defend a hypothesis against rivals, and learn to specify evidence that would tell them apart.
Scenario	Women's participation in paid work is low in a stylised district with growing towns. Each pod defends one explanation: care responsibilities; a lack of suitable local jobs; social norms about women's work; safety and transport; a mismatch of skills and education; or household income. Other pods will try to knock it down.
Group size	Six pods or pairs, one explanation each
Time	45 minutes (Thursday challenge)
Materials	Six explanation cards; Timer; A register template on the board
Expected output	Six sharpened hypotheses with disconfirming tests

Steps.

1. Turn your explanation into one testable hypothesis.
2. Write the evidence that would support it and the evidence that would weaken it.
3. Present it in 90 seconds.
4. Each other pod gets one challenge: a rival explanation or a disconfirming test.
5. Revise, and name the evidence that would decide between you and your strongest rival.

Facilitation. The aim is to sharpen, not to win. Award no points for persuasion; award them for the most precise disconfirming test. Point out that several explanations can be partly true at once, which is why the register keeps rivals rather than declaring a winner. The Periodic Labour Force Survey is the obvious public source if participants ask what data could decide.

Debrief questions.

- Which hypothesis became most testable through challenge?
- Which rival explanations could both be true at once?
- What published data could decide between the strongest pair?

Evaluation criteria	Common errors
The hypothesis is falsifiable	Vague hypotheses that cannot fail
Disconfirming evidence is stated	Only supporting evidence offered
A rival and a discriminating test are named	Rivals rejected without evidence

Extension for strong groups. Combine two hypotheses into an interaction: when would both be needed for the effect to appear?

Workbook application: Worksheet 4.2, Hypothesis register

Turn your priority branches into hypotheses that evidence could prove wrong, each with a rival. Ask each participant to read one hypothesis and its disconfirming test aloud to their pod sceptic.

Hand in. Worksheet 4.2 by the start of Day 10, for Gate 2.

Independent work

For each hypothesis, find one published source that could test it, and check that it covers your place and period. About 45 minutes.

Assessment

Gate 2 (Day 10). Feedback uses F1, F2 and F3 and tracker codes HY1 and HY2.

Readings

- Essential: Bardach and Patashnik, A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis, part I, step two: assemble some evidence.
- Optional: Heuer, Richards J., Jr. Psychology of Intelligence Analysis. Center for the Study of Intelligence, 1999. Chapter 8, analysis of competing hypotheses.

Close and transition

Exit task: Write the single piece of evidence that would most damage your favourite hypothesis. Transition: Tomorrow you turn the register into a workplan, open your evidence register and submit Gate 2.

Day 10: The workplan

Item	Detail
Week	2: Situate and prioritise (Friday)
Central question	What exactly will we investigate, with which evidence, and by when?
Session outcome	Each participant has built a workplan linking each priority hypothesis to an analysis, a source and a deadline, opened your evidence register, and submitted Gate 2.
Competencies	E1, E2
Anchor tool	Workplan matrix: hypothesis, question, analysis, source, deadline
Supporting tools (demonstrated only)	Evidence gap analysis; The evidence register
Theory link	None today.
Gate	Gate 2 is due today.

Learning objectives

1. Turn each priority hypothesis into a research question.
2. Link each question to an analysis, a named source and a deadline.
3. Identify evidence gaps and decide how to handle them.
4. Open the evidence register.

Session plan

Minutes	Block	Length
0 to 10	Opening problem	10 minutes
10 to 20	Concept: from register to workplan	10 minutes
20 to 35	Demonstration: Madhyapur workplan	15 minutes
35 to 60	Activity: missing data challenge	25 minutes
60 to 100	Gate 2: pod peer review	40 minutes
100 to 120	Debrief and planning	20 minutes

Preparation and materials

- The Day 10 slide deck (03 Slides)
- Worksheet 4.3 in Workbook 4
- Scenario card
- A source menu card listing typical public sources

Indian policy context

The rural employment guarantee's management information system publishes extensive data on works, payments and delays, often richer than analysts expect. Knowing what a public system already publishes is part of designing a feasible workplan.

Teaching narrative, slide by slide

Slide 1. Title slide. Gate day. Gate 2 covers Worksheets 3.1, 3.2, 4.1, 4.2 and today's 4.3. The revision note must respond to Gate 1 feedback.

Slide 2. Today. Session outcome: by the end of the session each participant has built a workplan linking each priority hypothesis to an analysis, a source and a deadline, opened your evidence register, and submitted Gate 2.

Slide 3. Opening problem. This is McKinsey step four: build a workplan. The question in the slide is the ordering principle: start with the analysis that could most change the answer, not the one that is easiest.

Slide 4. The workplan matrix: Madhyapur. H5 has been dropped from the workplan: it is a quick check, answerable from the same city reports. Note that every source is published. Where the source is the stylised corporation's own records, a real case would cite the specific document and year.

Slide 5. Three questions before you commit to a source. These three questions prevent the most common Week 3 failure: discovering on Day 12 that the source does not cover the case. Ask each participant to apply them to their first workplan row now.

Slide 6. Evidence gaps: name them, do not hide them. An honest limitation says what it could change about the conclusion, not just that it exists. Ask: if this gap were filled, could the recommendation change?

Slide 7. The evidence register opens today. Stress that the register is kept as the work happens, not reconstructed at the end. The verified and AI fields enforce the course rule that AI output is never evidence: every claim must be traced to a source.

Slide 8. Activity: The missing data challenge. The lesson is that good analysts design around data constraints rather than wishing them away. Push pods to be specific about level and period. Mention that the scheme's management information system publishes extensive data, often richer than participants expect.

Slide 9. Gate 2 pod peer review: 40 minutes. Ask reviewers to test one hypothesis from each register for falsifiability. That is the most common weakness at Gate 2.

Slide 10. Your case: Worksheet 4.3. Individual application, about 20 minutes. Circulate and check that every participant is working on their own case. Check every workplan row for a named source; a row that says government data is not yet a plan.

Slide 11. What to take away. Ask two participants to state the takeaway they found least obvious, then close with the exit task: Write the date by which your first analysis will be done.

Slide 12. Before the next session. Rest, then start the first analysis in your workplan. About 30 minutes.

Likely misconceptions

Misconception	How to respond
More sources mean better research.	Relevant, reliable sources at the right level matter more than volume.
If the data do not exist, the question cannot be answered.	Often a weaker but available proxy, honestly qualified, is good enough for the decision.
The register is administration.	It is how a reader checks your claims, and it carries marks.

Discussion questions

Question	What strong answers include
How do you choose between a strong source at the wrong level and a weaker source at the right level?	It depends on what the decision needs. Strong answers use both and say how each qualifies the other.

Question	What strong answers include
What makes a limitation honest?	It says what the gap could change about the conclusion, not just that the gap exists.

Activity: The missing data challenge

Element	Detail
Purpose	Design a feasible research plan when the ideal data do not exist.
Scenario	A state wants to know why wage payments under the rural employment guarantee reach some workers late in a stylised district. You have four weeks, no field access and only published sources. Assume you cannot obtain worker-level payment records with reasons for delay in that time.
Group size	Pods of four
Time	25 minutes
Materials	Scenario card; A source menu card listing typical public sources
Expected output	A two-analysis plan with stated limitations

Steps.

1. Write down the ideal dataset you would want.
2. List published sources that could stand in for it, such as scheme reports, audits and studies.
3. For each, note what it can and cannot tell you.
4. Choose the two analyses that would most change the answer.
5. Write the limitation you would state in the final report.

Facilitation. The lesson is that good analysts design around data constraints rather than wishing them away. Push pods to be specific about level and period. Mention that the scheme's management information system publishes extensive data, often richer than participants expect.

Debrief questions.

- What did you give up by moving from the ideal to the available data?
- Which limitation would a sceptical reader find most serious?
- Did anyone find a source richer than expected?

Evaluation criteria	Common errors
Ideal and available data distinguished	Planning analyses no source can support
Two analyses chosen with reasons	Ignoring level and period
Limitation stated honestly	Hiding the gap

Extension for strong groups. Design the primary research you would commission with six months and a budget, and say what it would add.

Workbook application: Worksheet 4.3, Workplan and evidence register

Commit to the analyses that matter most, with sources and dates, and start the record of your evidence. Check every workplan row for a named source; a row that says government data is not yet a plan.

Hand in. Gate 2 (Worksheets 3.1, 3.2, 4.1, 4.2 and 4.3, revised) by the end of Day 10. Feedback returned by Day 12.

Independent work

Rest, then start the first analysis in your workplan. About 30 minutes.

Assessment

Gate 2: detailed feedback on domains D, F and the first part of E (E1 and E2) under the five headings. Formative.

Readings

- Essential: The methods note or data documentation for the main dataset in your workplan: read how it was collected and at what level it is representative.
- Optional: A PRS Legislative Research budget analysis for your sector or state.

Close and transition

Exit task: Write the date by which your first analysis will be done. Transition: Week 3 begins with finding and judging evidence in the Indian data ecosystem.